

Notice:

This zine contains no images, and
the typography is terrible.
But it's still a zine.

**Neckup
Checkup
#1
(a perzine)**

by Dezz Emme

This is my very first
zine, and it's about
itself.

There'll be another
one. Thanks to
Brown Recluse
Zine Distro,
Maranda Elizabeth
and the number 91.

The point was to make it, to do the thing I dreamed of doing when my hair was pink and I wore bootcut corduroys and listened to Cat Power songs on endless loops. This is page 8 of 8. It doesn't feel monumental, paradigm-shifting. But it does feel more like a start than a finish.

It took me 25 years to make this zine. I first heard of them in college, and I was so smitten that I designed an independent study project about them, but I didn't finish it. I wanted to make one of my own, but I was too intimidated.

I read the raw, powerful, banal, cute, inspiring, infuriating work of zinesters around the world, and I felt like nothing I contributed would be Authentic. I had internalized that I was a pretender to the throne of writer, poet, artist, whatever. Some dickheads in my life validated this, and that's what stuck, not the people who encouraged me to keep writing and making art.

I don't think this little thing has anything to offer anyone. Everyone has heard the advice to just do it. Nike started that campaign in 1988. (I had to look that up, just like I had to double check the lyrics for "Winter.") But maybe that doesn't matter. It doesn't matter if anyone thinks this is Good or gets something out of reading it. Or if anyone reads it at all.

I can't stand meta-writing. Billy Collins is my least favorite poet. I feel silly and pretentious making this dumb zine about making this dumb zine. But I only have two more pages to finish, and the knot choking off my small intestine from the large is loosening a little.

Eventually, I stopped doing anything creative at all. Zines, small presses and comics I loved grew, blossomed, faded and were reborn as other things, replaced by other efforts. But I just stood still, as the Tori Amos song says, "withering where some snowman was."

I'm in my 40s now, and I'm finally trying. This is it, the trying. I found this template through Brown Recluse, and I'm grateful to them for lowering the threshold for action practically below ground level. I made a copy of it on Canva and said, tomorrow I'll make my first zine.

I didn't know what to write about or how I wanted it to look, but I knew I wouldn't have a clearer vision of this 8 page zine tomorrow. It's a cliché that the hardest part of doing something new and terrifying is to start doing it, but I was stuck, frozen even after I told myself to just make a zine. Just fill in the panels; it doesn't matter what you fill them in with. Just break the seal, ha ha.